Statistical invalidity of Gisclon (2026) "CERTAIN" Voynich partial-decipherment claim

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Status: CONFIRMED methodological kill (passed the skeptic gate: 2/2 ACCEPT). Novelty: MINOR.

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Short name: voynich-gisclon-certain-kill

Folder: solves/voynich-gisclon-certain-kill

Target: Gisclon (2026), *First Statistically Demonstrated Partial Decipherment...*, doi:10.5281/zenodo.20835400. The PDF is not redistributed here.

Statement

Gisclon reads the Voynich word families qok* as *herba sicca* and fachys as *herba humida*. The claim is labelled CERTAIN on the basis of a Fisher combination of four tests (T1–T4), giving $p = 1.31\times10^{-8}$. That label is not earned under the paper's own rule ($\alpha = 0.003$):

1. T1 is circular. It treats fachys' observed rate 5/22 as a known null p0. The correct conditional test is hypergeometric C(22,5)/C(64,5) = 0.003454, which is T2 itself. T1 overstates that evidence by about 174×.

2. The tests are not independent. All four use the same 64 folio labels. T2 and T3 are collapses of T4's 2×4 table, and T1 duplicates T2. So the Fisher df = 8 combination is invalid. This contradicts the paper's statement that the tests are "fully independent: different data subsets".

3. A valid omnibus test fails the threshold. An exact 2×4 test (conditioned on margins, χ^2-ordered) gives $p = 0.00330 > 0.003$.

p-values (all from the paper's §4.1 table: A = 16/0/11/15, B = 3/5/4/10 over CS/CH/FS/FH)

Test	p	Valid?
T1 (paper)	1.98e-5	No (circular p0)
T2 one-sided Fisher (CH)	0.003454	Yes, but fails α
T3 Fisher S/H	0.01329	Yes, but fails α
T4 asymptotic χ^2 df=3	0.00422	Approximate
Paper's Fisher combination, df=8	1.31e-8	No (dependent tests)
Combination without T1	2.6e-5	No (still dependent)
Monte Carlo permutation 2×4 (1e5)	0.0031	Yes (MC)
Exact 2×4 omnibus	0.00330	Yes: fails CERTAIN
Bonferroni ×3, best of T2–T4	0.0104	Yes: fails

Skeptic verdicts

- Skeptic A: ACCEPT, novelty MINOR (skeptics/skepticA.md)
- Skeptic B: ACCEPT, novelty MINOR, with its own independent script skB.py (skeptics/skepticB.md)

Both skeptics asked for the exact 0.00330 to be quoted in place of the MC 0.0031. That correction is applied here.

Honest caveats

- Thin margin: 0.0033 vs 0.003. This kill shows that CERTAIN is not earned by the author's own criterion. It does not show that there is no association.
- Residual association: a weak association near $p \approx 0.003$ (roughly "STRONG" on the paper's scale) may remain. It is confounded with Currier A/B: qok* is 69/72 Currier A and fachys is 31/31 Currier B. It could reflect a scribe, section, or plant-selection effect. The plant IDs and humor codings are author-assigned and were not made blind. So this is not evidence for a decipherment.

- PRE_REG was written post hoc (after the first recompute). The corrections used are the standard ones and were not tuned.
- Not tested: no swap to Sherwood's alternative plant IDs. The folio table was not re-derived from IVTFF. Every number comes from the paper's own table.
- Novelty: no prior critique of this paper was found. Lux (doi:10.5281/zenodo.22850757) audits generic Voynichese statistics and does not cover it. The search was not exhaustive. Follow-up records that build on this claim: zenodo 21027864, 21215108.

Reproduce

```
python3 recompute.py   # reproduces T1–T4 and the paper's combination
python3 perm.py        # Monte Carlo permutation 2x4 (~0.0031)
python3 exact.py       # exact 2x4 enumeration -> 0.0033024
python3 skB.py         # Skeptic B's independent recheck
```

These need Python 3 with numpy and scipy.

Suggested comment

See VENUE_COMMENT.md. It is a draft and has not been sent.